

Could You Be Dreaming Right Now? Descartes, Skepticism, and the Brain in a Vat

An original lesson plan inspired by **Declan Smithies's** *Theory of Knowledge (24.211)* (MIT OpenCourseWare). Not affiliated with or endorsed by MIT OpenCourseWare or Declan Smithies. Explore the original course: <https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/24-211-theory-of-knowledge-spring-2014/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 10-12

DURATION

55 minutes

TOPICS

Epistemology

“How do you actually know you're not dreaming right now, or a brain in a vat being fed a perfectly convincing simulated world — and does it matter if you can't rule it out?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Reconstruct the stages of Descartes's method of doubt, from the unreliability of the senses through the dreaming argument to the evil demon hypothesis.
- Explain the brain-in-a-vat thought experiment as a modern version of the same skeptical structure.
- Evaluate at least two different philosophical responses to radical skepticism.

Materials Needed

- Short excerpt handout from Descartes's *Meditations*, Meditation I (the dreaming argument and evil demon hypothesis)
- Whiteboard for recording the class's proposed “certainties”
- Optional: a short (2–3 minute) clip or plot summary of a film using the brain-in-a-vat premise, to use as a hook

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Can You Be Completely Certain Of?

8 min

Ask students to write down one thing they are absolutely, 100% certain of — something no possible scenario could make false. Collect answers on the board (common ones: “I exist,” “ $2+2=4$,” “the sun will rise tomorrow”). For each, ask: is there really no way this could be wrong? Push gently on the empirical ones especially, previewing the skeptical scenarios to come.

Direct Instruction: Descartes's Method of Doubt

15 min

Walk through the escalating stages of Descartes's doubt from the excerpt: first, the senses sometimes deceive us, so we can't trust them uncritically; second, we can't rule out that we're currently dreaming, since dreams can feel entirely real while they're happening; third, and most radical, we can't even rule out an evil demon systematically deceiving us about everything, including mathematics. Note that Descartes isn't trying to convince anyone they really might be dreaming forever — he's using the doubt to find something that survives even this.

Modernizing the Argument: Brain in a Vat

10 min

Introduce the brain-in-a-vat scenario as a modern-dress version of the evil demon: a scientist has removed your brain and is feeding it electrical signals producing a perfectly convincing simulated world. Ask: what, if anything, is different about this scenario from Descartes's demon? What kind of evidence, if any, could ever distinguish being a brain in a vat from having a normal body in the real world?

Socratic Seminar: Responding to Skepticism

17 min

Facilitate a discussion introducing two possible responses without necessarily resolving the debate: (1) a pragmatic response — even if we can't logically rule out these scenarios, it's still rational to act as if the external world is real, since we have no better alternative; (2) a contextualist response — the standards for what counts as “knowledge” shift depending on context, so ordinary claims like “I know I have hands” can be true in everyday contexts even if they'd fail a philosophy seminar's stricter standard. Ask students which response, if either, they find satisfying.

Closure: Reflective Writing

5 min

Students write for a few minutes on: “Does it actually bother you that you can't rule out being a brain in a vat? Why or why not?” Collect a few volunteers to share before ending class.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If you truly could never distinguish being a brain in a vat from having a normal body in the real world, does that possibility actually matter for how you should live?
- 2 Descartes claims that “I think, therefore I am” survives even the evil demon's deception. Can you think of anything else that might survive it?
- 3 Is it a weakness of the contextualist response that a claim like “I know I have hands” could be simultaneously true and false depending only on what conversation you're having?
- 4 Does modern technology (deepfakes, virtual reality, AI-generated content) make Descartes's skeptical scenarios feel more urgent than they did in the 17th century, or is the philosophical problem unchanged?

Assessment

Students write a short response explaining Descartes's method of doubt in their own words and evaluating whether the brain-in-a-vat scenario poses a genuinely new philosophical problem or is simply the evil demon in different clothing.



Extension Activity

Have students research one additional skeptical scenario from philosophy or popular culture (e.g., simulation theory) and write a short comparison to Descartes's evil demon, noting what, if anything, is philosophically new about it.

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